

THE HURDLE RACE

While the UPA might have scored on the diplomatic front, the Left has held the Government to ransom on economic policies

JUNE 2004: The Left did not allow Indian troops to be sent to Iraq. It condemned a joint press conference of former foreign minister Natwar Singh and former US secretary of state Colin Powell in Washington.

SEPTEMBER 2004: Representatives of the World Bank and ADB, who had been hired as consultants by the Planning Commission, had to resign after protests by the Left.

FEBRUARY 2005: Calling the telecommunications sector strategic, the

insurance and pension sectors through reforms.

FEBRUARY 2006: The Civil Aviation Ministry's bid to modernise airports met with stiff resistance from the Left. It insisted that the Kolkata and Chennai airports be retained by AAI.

MARCH 2006: The Left did not allow visiting US President George Bush to address a Parliament session.

JUNE 2006: With help from DMK, the Left stalled the disinvestment of 10

Sabha in protest against his pro-World Bank policies. As long as he was allowed to steer the nation's foreign policy, the prime minister let the Left dictate the economics. He got away with the Iran vote and believed that after a token opposition, the Left would support him on the nuclear deal. He was wrong. And he refused to be bullied into submission. The finance minister who moved about with a resignation letter in his pocket, has evolved into an aggressive prime minister who is now asking others to resign.

Congress President Sonia Gandhi too has gone out of her way to express her support to Manmohan, making an unprecedented visit to the Central Hall where she spoke in the deal's favour. She has no intention of downsizing her prime minister on an issue that bears his world view. Manmohan, in retrospect, had a comparatively easy time with the American president. Enter Prakash Karat and Manmohan's diplomatic skills have proved to be of little use. What's on display is the political skill of a man who has never been a politician in the conventional sense of the word.

The prime minister knows he is dealing with a formidable antagonist. As general secretary of a party that has internalised the detritus of the Soviet apparatus, Karat lives by the book, and as an ideological purist who remains untouched by history, he is perhaps the true inheritor of E.M.S. Namboodiripad's mantle. Manmohan, a reformist of the marketplace, has been a victim of CPI(M)'s ideological diktats. The comrades have, to a great extent, contained the free marketer. Strangely, the prime minister suffered in submission. Manmohan didn't fight for his reformist cause. He didn't risk his Government for values that defined him as a market liberator. Where was the courage of conviction when AKG Bhavan set the limits for his economic agenda? Today, the failed reformer has become the audacious nuclear redeemer. There is an apparent role reversal. He intends to define the boundaries for the dictatorship of the Politburo. If he has the last nuclear laugh, it will be the beginning of Manmohan Singh's career as a politician. ■



REFORM ROW: P. Chidambaram and Montek Singh Ahluwalia

Left opposed increasing the FDI cap from 49 per cent. The then telecom minister Dayanidhi Maran spent a good part of his tenure explaining things to the Left. The FDI cap is 74 per cent now.

MAY 2005: The Government could not offload 10 per cent public equity in BHEL under pressure from the Left, which wanted the disinvestment ministry of the previous NDA regime to be discontinued.

JANUARY 2006: Foreign direct investment in many sectors including retail was partially blocked by the Left. The Congress could not liberalise the

per cent public equity in Nalco and Neyveli Lignite Corporation saying that sale of equities in profit-making PSUs was against the CMP.

JANUARY 2007: The Left asked the Government to make changes in the SEZ Act.

JULY 2007: Currently the Left is stalling Bills intended to further liberalise the banking and pension sector. It is also opposing the Seeds Bill and the Foreign Educational Institutions Bill.